

Unit 2: User Journey and Interaction Design

Chapter I: Personas & User Journey

Chapter I Agenda:

1. Personas: Creating a Persona
2. Using Personas in the Design Process
3. Empathy Maps
4. Identifying User Pain Points
5. Creating User Story and Scenarios
6. Problem Statements
7. Hypothesis Statements
8. Design Ideation
9. Translating requirements into design specifications
10. Competitive Audits
11. Interaction Design
12. Principles of Interaction Design
13. Designing User interactions and Flows
14. Techniques for Interaction Design

1. Personas

1.1 What Is a Persona, and Why Does It Matter?

A persona is a fictional character that represents a real segment of your users. It is built from actual research data — interviews, surveys, and analytics — not from guesswork. Even though the person is fictional, everything about them (their goals, habits, and frustrations) is grounded in patterns that showed up repeatedly across real users.

The purpose of a persona is simple: it humanises the data. Design teams find it far easier to make decisions for "Anna, the busy marketing manager who is frustrated by clunky software" than for "34% of surveyed users aged 28–40." Personas give teams a shared, memorable reference point so that every design decision can be checked against a specific person's needs rather than an abstract statistic.

💡 EXAMPLE — Stats vs. Stories

Telling a design team that "about 533,000 people over 100 years old are alive today" barely registers. But introducing them to Mavis Hunter — a 100-year-old competitive runner who only took up the sport two years ago — creates a lasting impression. Stories move people to design better; statistics rarely do.

1.2 Steps to Create a Persona

1. **Data synthesis.** Collect data through quantitative methods (surveys, analytics) and qualitative methods (interviews, ethnographic studies), then look for repeating patterns that represent distinct user segments.
2. **Build the persona template.** Turn each pattern into a persona using a consistent template (see below) so every persona in your set can be compared side by side.

A Typical Persona Includes

- **Name & demographics** — a representative (fictional) name, age, location, occupation, and family status.
- **Goals & motivations** — what the user is trying to achieve with the product.
- **Behaviours & habits** — how the user typically engages with similar products.
- **Pain points & challenges** — what frustrates the user or blocks their goals.
- **Technological proficiency** — how comfortable the user is with technology, and which devices they favour.
- **A quote or narrative** — a short line that captures the user's relationship with the product.

Persona Card Template



Photo

Name: [Persona Name]

Age • Occupation • Location
Family status • Tech comfort
"A short quote that captures this persona's relationship with the product."

- **Goals & Motivations**
What does this user want to achieve when using the product?
- **Behaviours & Habits**
How does this user typically engage with similar products?
- **Pain Points & Challenges**
What frustrates this user?
What blocks their goals?

Figure 1.1 — A reusable persona card template.



Sara Andersson

Age: 29 years

Occupation: Marketing Coordinator at a mid-sized company

Residence: An apartment in a medium-sized city, close to parks and green spaces

Dog: A two-year-old Border Collie MIX named Max

Personality:

Sara is an active and outgoing person who loves being outdoors. She's dedicated to both her work and social life, but her dog, Max, is her best friend and constant companion. She's also quite tech-savvy and often uses apps to organize her life—from workout sessions to cooking, and now, dog training.

Challenges and Goals:

Sara wants Max to be mentally stimulated and develop through fun and structured exercises. Max is an energetic dog who needs both physical and mental activity to thrive, but Sara has noticed that she's running out of ideas and structure for training. She's looking for a simple and inspiring guide to train him more effectively.

App Needs:

- **Training Plans:** Ready-made training programs and exercise suggestions that she can follow with Max.
- **Progress Log:** A feature that keeps track of which exercises Max has completed and how he's progressing.
- **Challenges and Rewards:** Sara appreciates gamified elements that reward both her and Max, helping to keep them motivated.
- **Community:** A place to share experiences or get tips from other dog owners in a community section.
- **Reminders:** She wants notifications that remind her when it's time for the day's training session.

Motivation:

Sara is motivated by seeing Max develop and wants him to have the best training possible to be a happy, well-balanced dog. She also enjoys documenting their progress and feeling that they're continuously reaching new goals together.

Fig: This is a visual persona card for Sara Andersson, summarizing her personality, goals, motivations, frustrations, and behavior patterns as a dog training app user.

💡 EXAMPLE — Two Well-Crafted Personas

Anna, the Busy Professional (34, Marketing Manager) wants quick, effective tools to manage campaigns. She is frustrated by overly complex software and prefers streamlined, intuitive interfaces. Her quote: "I need tools that get the job done fast, so I can focus on what really matters."

Jake, the Aspiring Student (21, College Student) needs resources that help him stay organised and study efficiently. He is overwhelmed by the volume of study material and jumps between platforms, which hurts his productivity. His quote: "I'm always looking for better ways to stay on top of my coursework."

As a rule of thumb, creating three to eight personas is usually enough to represent the majority of a product's user base. Personas are context-specific — they should describe how a person behaves in relation to your product, not their entire life story.

1.3 Using Personas in the Design Process

Personas are not a one-time deliverable that gets created and forgotten. They stay active throughout the design process in three main ways:

- **Persona-driven brainstorming** — during ideation, teams generate ideas aligned with a specific persona's needs. If a persona values speed, the team brainstorms features that remove steps.
- **Guiding design decisions** — personas help prioritise features. A feature that does not serve any key persona is deprioritised.
- **Validating design choices** — before finalising a decision, the team checks it against persona needs — for example, "does this new navigation actually simplify things for Anna?"

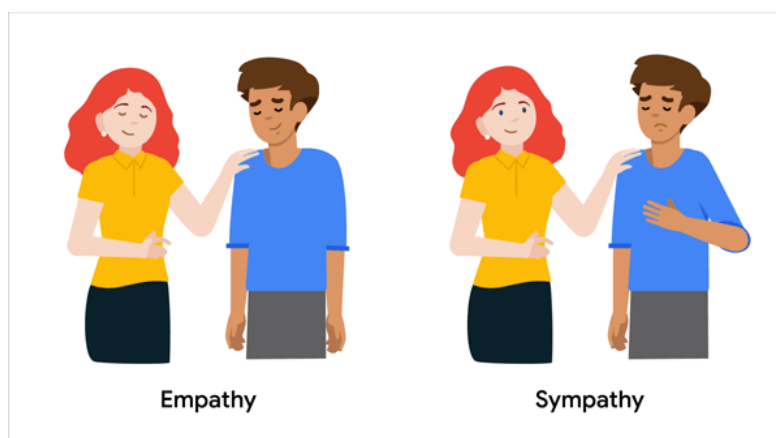
2. Empathy in UX Design

2.1 Why Empathy Comes First

UX stands for "user experience" — so the user's experience has to be at the centre of every design decision. Empathy is the ability to understand someone else's feelings or thoughts in a given situation. As a designer, the more accurately you can anticipate what your users need and feel, the more comfortable they will be with your design, and the more likely they are to keep using your product.

Empathy vs. Sympathy

These two words are often confused. Empathy means understanding someone's feelings by, in some sense, feeling them yourself. Sympathy means showing concern or compassion for someone without actually sharing the emotion. UX designers aim for empathy — a genuine, internal understanding of the user's experience — because it produces design decisions that truly fit the user's world.



2.2 Six Habits of an Empathetic Designer

- **Ask lots of questions.** Never assume what a user needs — ask, using "what," "how," and "why" questions.
- **Become more observant.** Watch body language and physical cues, not just words. Take notes or record sessions.
- **Be an active listener.** Concentrate fully on what the user is saying instead of planning your next question.
- **Request input from diverse sources.** Friends and colleagues tend to give biased, overly positive feedback — seek a wider, more objective pool of users.
- **Keep an open mind.** Set your own biases aside; your goal is to understand the user, not to filter their feedback through your own opinions.
- **Stay current on UX research.** Follow researchers and communities, since our understanding of human psychology keeps evolving.

2.3 Conducting User Interviews



Interviews remain the single richest source of empathy data a designer can gather. A good interview happens in four phases:

1. Prepare

- Script a consistent set of questions, but be ready to deviate if something interesting comes up.
- Gather your supplies (recording equipment, printed questions, notebook) in advance.
- Research each participant beforehand to build rapport and extend the conversation naturally.
- Practise your questions out loud so the interview runs smoothly and fits its time slot.

2. Meet the Participant

- Build rapport with light conversation before diving into questions.
- Thank participants for their time — it signals that their opinion is valued.
- Confirm basic demographic details relevant to the interview.

3. Conduct the Interview

- **Follow interview etiquette** — stay professional, nod, maintain eye contact, and take visible notes.
- **Ask open-ended questions** — favour "why" questions over ones that invite a simple yes/no. If you do get a short answer, follow up.

EXAMPLE — Closed vs. Open Questions

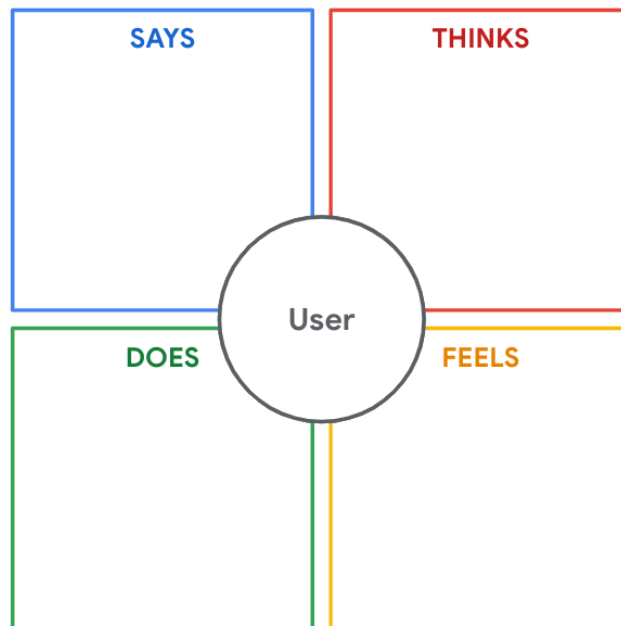
Instead of asking, "Do you like going to the library?" (closed), ask "Why do you like or dislike going to the library?" (open). The open version reveals reasoning you can actually design around.

4. Take Notes and End the Interview

- Highlight compelling quotes verbatim — they are gold for empathy maps.
- Document mood, body language, and any outside distractions that may have skewed responses.
- With consent, record the session so you can revisit details later.
- Close by inviting final thoughts, then thank the participant once more.



3. Empathy Maps



3.1 What Is an Empathy Map?

An empathy map is an easily-understood chart that summarises everything a designer has learned about a type of user. It is divided into four quadrants — Says, Thinks, Does, and Feels — arranged around the user at the centre.

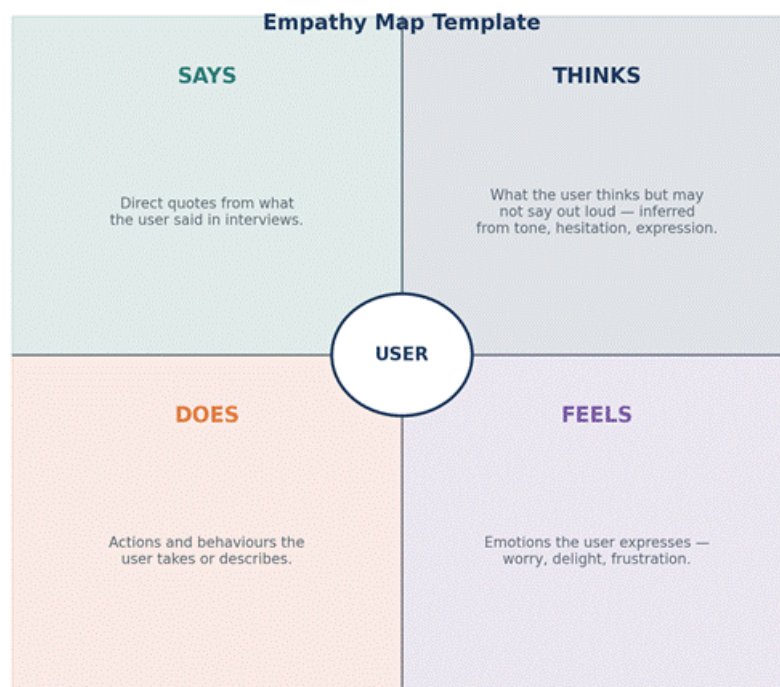


Figure 3.1 — The four quadrants of an empathy map.

The Four Quadrants

- **Says** — direct, verbatim quotes from the interview. Do not paraphrase; use the user's own words.

- **Does** — actions or behaviours the user describes, or that you observe during the interview.
- **Thinks** — what the user thinks but may not say aloud — inferred from tone, hesitation, or facial expression.
- **Feels** — the emotions the user expresses, either stated directly or observed through body language.

3.2 One-User vs. Aggregated Empathy Maps

There are two kinds of empathy maps. A one-user empathy map records the responses of a single interview participant. An aggregated (or multi-user) empathy map consolidates feedback from a group of similar users into one combined map, helping designers spot themes across an entire user segment.

3.3 Steps to Build an Empathy Map

1. **Add the user's name.** This lets you trace the map back to the original transcript later.
2. **Fill the Says square.** Use verbatim quotes — summarising risks misinterpreting the user's meaning.
3. **Fill the Thinks square.** Summarise thoughts and feelings you infer from tone or body language — but be careful to infer, not assume.
4. **Fill the Does square.** Record concrete actions and behaviours the user described.
5. **Fill the Feels square.** List emotions expressed, verbally or otherwise. If nothing was said explicitly, ask: "how does this make you feel?"

GOOD TO KNOW — Assumption vs. Inference

An assumption fills a gap with your own bias ("she mentioned her neighbour's teenage son, so she must want an adult dog walker"). An inference stays grounded in what was actually said ("she wants a dog walker with a car and licence, who could get her dog to an emergency vet"). Good empathy maps are built on inference, not assumption — when in doubt, ask the user to clarify.

EXAMPLE — Empathy Map for Makayla (Dog-Walking App)

Makayla, 45, is a teacher with two dogs and an unpredictable schedule.

Says: "I'd love to find a dog walker that I could prescreen." • "I'm willing to pay a little more to get...this."

Thinks: Wants to prescreen and book walkers consistently; dog walking feels expensive; doesn't know enough people to ask for help.

Does: Works full-time; walks the dogs morning and evening; pays a 17-year-old neighbour to help out.

Feels: Guilty when she can't walk the dogs; worried about her current walker's ability to handle an emergency.

